

The Trap Catalogue — How UPSC Manufactures a Wrong Answer

Chapter F11.4 — Thirty Structural Traps, the Confusion Pairs They Run On, and the Remedy for Each

Module	Foundation Layer — Module 11 — PYQ Analysis, Mocks and Final Revision
Chapter	Chapter F11.4
Topic	Distractor architecture, elimination discipline and the confusion-pair compendium
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MUST MASTER · WHY THIS CHAPTER EXISTS AT ALL

F11.1 §1.2 established the arithmetic that governs the whole paper: a **blind** guess is worth exactly zero, and **eliminating even one option turns a question positive**. Everything in the manual's attempt strategy rests on that.

But it rests on a hidden assumption. The arithmetic only holds if your eliminations are **real**. An elimination made because an option *feels* wrong, or because you half-recognise a number, is not an elimination — it is a coin flip you have mistaken for knowledge. And a distractor that persuades you to eliminate the **correct** option does not merely cost you the mark; it converts a zero-expectation guess into a **negative** one.

So the marking arithmetic tells you that elimination is everything. **This chapter is about making the eliminations true**. It is the other half of F11.1 §1.2, and without it that table is a licence to guess confidently and wrongly.

NOTE · SCOPE, AND WHAT THIS CHAPTER DELIBERATELY DOES NOT REPEAT

This chapter is **exam craft, not content**. It carries **no marks of its own**, like the rest of Module 11, and it is a multiplier on the other 300.

It does not repeat, and defers entirely to:

- **F11.1 §1.2** — the marking arithmetic and the elimination-value table. Referenced throughout, never

restated

- **F11.1 §1.3** — the three-pass method
- **F11.3 §1.1** — mock conditions; **§4.2** — the last four weeks; **§5** — examination-day protocol
- **F10.1 §4** — the current-affairs verification sweep, and F10.2 §2.2's *proposed / approved / notified*

discipline, which is the single most important trap in the current-affairs zone and is fully treated there

What is new here is the systematic catalogue of **distractor construction techniques** — the thirty recurring ways a wrong option is built — and the **confusion-pair compendium** in §6, which is a last-week revision asset rather than a teaching text.

KNOW · THE EVIDENCE POSITION, STATED PLAINLY

Per the manual's labelling convention, this chapter's claims sit as follows.

- The **paper structure** in §1.1 is **OFFICIAL** — 120 questions, 300 marks, two hours, one-third

negative marking, interview 100 marks, 75:25 final merit

- The **taxonomy** in §3 is an **ANALYTICAL ESTIMATE**. It is the author's classification of distractor

patterns observed across the UPSC paper family. No claim is made that UPSC recognises these categories or that any named trap has a measured frequency

- The **question bank** in §8 is **written fresh**. It is **not** a reproduction of any question paper.

Where a drill imitates a known paper convention, the convention is named. **No verbatim text from any copyrighted question paper appears in this chapter**

- **No weightage figure is asserted anywhere in this chapter**, because trap frequency has not been

counted and inventing a count would breach the manual's own standard

Where a statutory figure appears, it is there to illustrate a trap, **not** to serve as the authority for the figure. §5 says exactly where to verify each one.

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0. How This Chapter Works

STUDY SESSION · CHAPTER F11.4 — FOUR SESSIONS, THEN PERMANENT REFERENCE

1. **Session 1** — The stem protocol and the taxonomy of stem traps (§2, §3.1) ★★★★★
2. **Session 2** — Logic traps and candidate traps (§3.2, §3.3) ★★★★★
3. **Session 3** — The source-paper map and the numbers ledger (§4, §5) ★★★★★★
4. **Session 4** — The elimination ladder and format rules (§7), then the 30-question diagnostic (§8) ★★★★★

Roughly six hours across three days. Then the chapter changes function: **§6 becomes a weekly twenty-five-minute read**, and §10 goes on the wall.

Unlike a content chapter, this one is not finished when you have read it. It is finished when the §7 ladder runs **without conscious effort** in a mock.

WHY · THE THREE IDEAS THAT GENERATE EVERYTHING BELOW

1 A wrong option is manufactured, not random. Somebody chose the most attractive false thing that could sit beside the truth. There are a limited number of ways to do that. Learn them and you stop seeing four options and start seeing one answer plus three recognisable factory products.

2 The trap is usually in the stem, not the options. More marks are lost to misreading *how many of the above, which is NOT*, and *how many pairs* than to not knowing the content. Stem discipline is cheaper to install than syllabus coverage, and it pays in the first mock after you install it.

3 Confusion is pairwise. You are almost never confused about a fact in isolation. You are confused between two facts that sit next to each other — layoff and retrenchment, CRR and SLR, provision and reserve, Laspeyres and Paasche. The remedy is not more reading. It is a **single discriminating sentence** per pair, which is what §6 is.

1. The Ground the Traps Operate On

1.1 The paper, in one table

Element	Value
Stage 1	Recruitment Test — offline, pen and paper, OMR
Questions	120 objective multiple-choice
Marks	300, therefore 2.5 per question
Duration	2 hours — 60 seconds per question including bubbling
Negative marking	one third of the marks for that question, i.e. -0.8333
Medium	Bilingual, English and Hindi
Stage 2	Interview / Personality Test, 100 marks
Final merit	Recruitment Test and Interview at 75:25

OFFICIAL. The 2026 cycle notified the **APFC post only** — EPFO withdrew its earlier Enforcement Officer / Accounts Officer requisition, so **EO/AO is not notified in 2026**.

HIGH YIELD · WHAT THE EO/AO WITHDRAWAL DOES TO YOUR PRACTICE MATERIAL

With no separate EO/AO paper, the APFC paper is now the **only** vehicle for EPFO's accounting, auditing and enforcement content. The consequence is practical: **old EO/AO papers stop being a parallel syllabus and become direct practice material**. Treat them as in-scope, at the same priority as past APFC papers.

This is the single largest change to the practice-material question this cycle, and §4 places it in the full source map.

1.2 Why trap-literacy is the highest-leverage thing left

F11.1 §1.2's table says elimination is everything. Push on that one step further.

The value of an elimination depends entirely on whether it is **hard** or **soft** — a distinction that recurs so often below that it is worth fixing now.

	Definition	What it licenses
Hard elimination	You know a specific fact that contradicts the option	Full confidence. Raises your probability genuinely
Soft elimination	You do not recognise part of the option	Nothing. Keep the option in the pool

TRAP · THE MECHANISM BY WHICH THE MARKING ARITHMETIC BETRAYS YOU

Treating a soft elimination as hard is how a candidate ends up at **60% accuracy while believing they are at 80%**. F11.1 §1.2 shows that 110 attempts at 70% scores less than 100 at 80%; the whole gap is manufactured by soft eliminations misread as hard.

Every trap in §3 works by producing a false hard elimination, a false hard confirmation, or both. That is the definition of a trap in this chapter, and the reason this chapter belongs in Module 11 rather than in a content module.

Note also the refinement F11.1 §1.2 already gives, which is the seed of the whole taxonomy: leave a question blank when you feel **actively pulled towards a familiar-looking option**, because that pull usually means you have half-recognised a trap. §3.3's T-25 is that instinct, made explicit.

2. The Six-Second Stem Protocol ★★★★★

Apply this to **every** question, before reading any option. It costs about six seconds and removes the largest category of avoidable error in the paper.

ACTION · THE PROTOCOL, IN ORDER

1. **If the stem is long, read its last clause first.** The operative instruction lives at the end
2. **Circle the negation**, if any — *not, except, incorrect, false, other than*
3. **Circle the quantifier** — *how many, only, all, both, which one*
4. **Name the task type** — single fact, statement adjudication, pair count, ordering, assertion-reason, best-answer, computation
5. **Note the scope words** — *all, every, throughout, since, only, any*
6. **Only now, read all four options** — and read **all four**, even when (a) looks certain

MEMORY · THE FIVE-ITEM VERSION, IF YOU RETAIN NOTHING ELSE

These five cost almost no preparation time and reliably recover marks in the high single figures.

1. **Circle the negation** (T-01)
2. **Read all four options before marking** (T-24)
3. **Mark every *and, or, not* in a statutory option** (T-17)
4. **Assign every number to its statute and its vintage** — do not merely recognise it (T-09)
5. **Audit the OMR in blocks of ten** (T-30)

3. The Taxonomy — Thirty Structural Traps

These are **content-free**. Each works identically on polity, on the EPF & MP Act, on accounting and on English. Each entry gives the shape, why able candidates fall for it, and the decision rule.

3.1 Group A — Traps in the stem

T-01 The inverted instruction ★★★★★

Shape. The stem asks for the exception, with *NOT*, *EXCEPT*, *INCORRECT* arriving late in a long sentence, past the point where the eye has begun scanning options.

Why it works. Reading is predictive. Your brain builds the expected question — *which is correct* — from the opening words, then pattern-matches options against that expectation. The negation is read but not applied.

Remedy. Circle the negation before looking at any option, then consciously restate the task: *I am hunting the false one; three of these will be true and I must resist them*. Say it internally. Two seconds, and it is the cheapest insurance in the paper.

T-02 The double negative ★★★☆☆

Shape. A negation in the stem **and** one inside the option — *which of the following is not incorrect*, or a body *not excluded* from a provision.

Remedy. Rewrite, do not reason. Cancel the pair in the margin and restate positively in three words. *Not incorrect* becomes *true*. Never hold two negations in working memory.

T-03 The quantified stem — *how many of the above are correct* ★★★★★

Shape. Four statements; options are *Only one* / *Only two* / *Only three* / *All four*.

Why it works. This is the most punishing format in use, and the reason is mathematical rather than psychological. In the older *1 and 2 only* format, confident knowledge of two statements often uniquely determined the answer. In the count format you must adjudicate **every** statement correctly. **One uncertain statement destroys the question.** It converts partial knowledge into zero, and it removes the elimination leverage that F11.1 §1.2 shows the entire attempt strategy depends on.

CHECK YOURSELF · THE THREE-PART COUNT PROTOCOL

1. **Adjudicate each statement in isolation**, writing **T**, **F** or **?** physically beside it
2. **Never guess the count from a feeling.** The count must be arithmetic on your own marks
3. **If you have even one ?**, treat the question as elimination-only: check whether both candidate counts appear among the options. If they do and the ? will not resolve, this is a genuine probability-sweep question, not a knowledge question — and per F11.1 §1.2 you should still attempt it

T-04 The best-answer question disguised as a correct-answer question ★★★★★

Shape. Two or more options are factually true, but one is more complete or more directly responsive. The stem carries a silent superlative — *the principal objective, the most appropriate, or merely the objective.*

Remedy. When a second option also looks true, **do not resolve by re-checking truth.** Resolve by **scope matching**: re-read the stem, fix its exact scope, and take the option whose scope is identical — neither broader nor narrower.

T-05 Scope creep in the stem ★★★★★

Shape. A familiar fact wrapped in a slightly widened scope — *in all States and Union Territories, for every establishment, throughout India, since inception.*

Why it works. The fact is recognised, and recognition suppresses scrutiny of the qualifier.

Remedy. Underline every scope word, then ask one question of each: **is there a known exception?** If yes, the option is false.

T-06 The pair-count matching question ★★★★★

Shape. Consider the following pairs. How many pairs are correctly matched? — typically Act and year, scheme and ministry, committee and subject, Article and content.

Why it works. The T-03 mathematics, plus a characteristic construction: one pair **famous and correct** to build confidence, one **famous and subtly wrong** which is the actual test, and one **obscure** which is pure noise.

Remedy. Adjudicate in order of **your** confidence, not the printed order. Resolve the certain pairs first; that often fixes the count without the obscure pair mattering at all. If it does not, prefer the count that requires the **famous-but-subtly-wrong** pair to be wrong — that is the pair the question was built around.

T-07 Absolute qualifiers in the options ★★★★★

Shape. *always, never, only, all, none, must, invariably, in no case, cannot.*

Remedy. The highest-yield elimination heuristic available: **absolutes are false far more often than true**, because Indian statutory reality is built of provisos and exemptions. When an option says *only* or *never*, spend your effort constructing **one** counter-example; find it and you have a **hard** elimination.

TRAP · DO NOT LET T-07 BECOME SUPERSTITION

Absolutes **are** true where the statute itself is absolute. A Money Bill can be introduced **only** in the Lok Sabha. Article 360 has **never** been invoked. Under the EPF & MP Act, an establishment once covered **continues** to be covered even if strength falls below the threshold.

Use the heuristic to **direct suspicion**, never to decide alone. An elimination made on the presence of the word *never*, with no supporting fact, is a **soft** elimination wearing a hard elimination's clothes — exactly the failure §1.2 warns about.

T-08 Hedged qualifiers in the options ★★★★★

Shape. The mirror image — *generally, usually, may, often, some, ordinarily, tends to*.

Why it works. Hedged statements feel evasive, so candidates eliminate them as insufficiently committal. But a hedged claim is very hard to **falsify**, and setters hedge in order to make **true** statements survive scrutiny.

Remedy. **Never eliminate an option merely for being cautious.** Forced to choose between an absolute and a hedged option with no other basis, take the hedged one.

T-09 The near-miss number ★★★★★

Shape. The correct figure with one digit, one order of magnitude, or one adjacent statutory value changed.

Why it works — and this is the key insight for this paper: the distractor is **not invented**. It is either the **superseded** value or the **correct value from a neighbouring statute**. Your memory contains it, correctly, filed in a different slot.

Remedy. §5's numbers ledger, and one habit: when a number appears, do not ask *does this look right*. Ask **which slot does this number belong to**. Recognition without slot-assignment is precisely what the trap eats.

T-10 Section and Article number swaps ★★★★★

Shape. Correct content attached to the wrong Article, Section, Schedule or Chapter.

Remedy. Learn numbers in **clusters with a narrative**, never as isolated pairs. The Directive Principles on labour run as a story — 39 health and strength of workers, 41 right to work and public assistance, 42 just and humane conditions and maternity relief, 43 living wage, 43A workers' participation. Rehearse the run, not the pairs.

T-11 Act name and year swaps ★★★★★

Remedy. A **recitable chronology** makes a year-swap visible instantly. Workmen's Compensation 1923, Trade Unions 1926, Payment of Wages 1936, Standing Orders 1946, Industrial Disputes 1947, Minimum Wages 1948, ESI 1948, EPF & MP 1952, Maternity Benefit 1961, Payment of Bonus 1965, Contract Labour 1970, Payment of Gratuity 1972, Equal Remuneration 1976, EDLI Scheme 1976, Unorganised Workers' Social Security 2008 — then the Codes: **Wages 2019**, and Industrial Relations, Social Security, and OSH & WC all **2020**.

And now the second layer, which matters more. Those Acts are **repealed**: the Codes were **enacted** in 2019 and 2020 but **commenced on 21 November 2025**, and the provident fund, pension and insurance schemes were replaced by **2026** schemes on **29 June 2026**. **Enactment year and commencement date are two different questions** — see §5.

T-12 The category swap — constitutional, statutory, executive ★★★★★

Shape. A body given the wrong legal pedigree. EPFO's Central Board of Trustees called constitutional; NITI Aayog called statutory; the Finance Commission called statutory.

Remedy. Rehearse **three lists**, not individual bodies.

Pedigree	Members
Constitutional	Election Commission, Finance Commission, CAG, UPSC and State PSCs, Attorney General, National Commission for SCs and STs
Statutory	NHRC, CVC, CIC, National Commission for Women, SEBI, RBI, NGT, ESIC , and EPFO's Central Board of Trustees — now under the Code on Social Security
Executive / non-statutory	NITI Aayog , the erstwhile Planning Commission, most Cabinet Committees

T-13 The plausible-but-nonexistent entity ★★☆☆

Shape. A scheme, committee or body that sounds entirely reasonable and does not exist, or that conflates two real names.

Why it works. Non-recognition is **ambiguous** — you cannot tell *I have not heard of this* from *this does not exist* — and candidates resolve the ambiguity against themselves.

Remedy. Invert the default, carefully. If you have prepared the scheme landscape and a name is wholly unfamiliar, that is **weak** evidence of fabrication rather than evidence of your own gap. Weak. Combine it with the other options; never decide on it alone, because the mirror error is T-26.

3.2 Group B — Traps in the logic

T-14 True statement, false reason ★★★★★

Shape. Assertion-Reason, or a composite *X happens because Y*. Assertion true, Reason true, and the Reason does **not** explain the Assertion.

Why it works. Two verified truths produce a feeling of correctness that overwhelms the requirement of a **causal link**.

Remedy. A fixed order, never varied. **One:** is A true? **Two:** is R true? **Three — only if both are true —** does R, by itself, produce A? Most candidates collapse steps two and three. Force the pause. Note that *both true, R does not explain A* is the correct answer far more often than candidates select it.

T-15 Reversed causation ★★★★★★

Shape. A genuine relationship stated backwards — *a rise in the repo rate increases money supply*.

Remedy. State the **mechanism** in your own words, in one clause, before judging. If you cannot articulate the mechanism you cannot evaluate the direction, and the option is **unresolved**, not plausible.

T-16 Necessary confused with sufficient ★★★★★

Shape. A necessary condition presented as sufficient. *Completion of five years of continuous service entitles an employee to gratuity* — ignoring that death and disablement **waive** the requirement, and that entitlement also needs the establishment to be covered.

Remedy. Two separate questions of every conditional option: is this condition **required**, and is it **enough**? Statutory eligibility is almost always conjunctive **plus** provisos, so *enough* is usually false.

T-17 The *and* / *or* switch ★★★★★

Shape. One conjunction changed. A statutory test reading *or* rendered as *and*, or the reverse.

Why it works. Conjunctions are function words; the eye does not fixate on them. Yet they invert the legal meaning completely.

Remedy. In any statutory or definitional option, **physically mark every *and*, *or* and *not***. Those three words carry more trap density per character than any content word in the paper.

T-18 Superset for subset ★★★★★★

Shape. *All* claimed where only *some* is true; a general rule asserted without its carve-out.

Remedy. For every universal claim about a statute, actively recall the **exemption provision**. Indian labour statutes essentially all have one. If you can name it, the universal claim is false.

T-19 Chronology traps ★★★★★★

Shape. Ordering questions, or a stem asserting that one event preceded another.

Why it works. Candidates store events as a **set**, not a sequence.

Remedy. Do not memorise sequences — memorise **anchor years** and interpolate. And see §7.3: on an ordering question, identify only the **earliest and latest** events, which you almost certainly know, then discard every option inconsistent with both. That usually resolves the question without the middle terms.

T-20 The relative-magnitude trap ★★☆☆☆

Shape. A comparison between two quantities you both know but have never **compared**.

Remedy. Whenever you learn two comparable quantities, record the **ordering** as a separate fact. *Fiscal deficit exceeds revenue deficit exceeds primary deficit* is not derivable at speed from the definitions alone. Store it as its own line.

T-21 The definitional near-synonym ★★★★★

Shape. Two terms that ordinary language treats as synonyms and the statute or standard does not. Layoff and retrenchment. Provision and reserve. Devaluation and depreciation.

Remedy. §6 exists for this and only this. For each pair, hold **one discriminating sentence that mentions both** — not two definitions.

T-22 The partially-true composite option ★★★★★

Shape. A long option whose first clause is unambiguously correct and whose later clause is wrong.

Remedy. Read every option **to its final word**, then **re-read the tail**. Trap clauses cluster at the end of long options, because that is where attention is weakest.

T-23 The overqualified true statement ★★★★★

Shape. A true statement made false by an added specific — the right provision with the wrong commencement date, the right scheme with the wrong ministry, the right committee with the wrong chair.

Remedy. Decompose into **atomic claims** and verify each. **One false atom falsifies the option**, however many true atoms accompany it.

3.3 Group C — Traps in the candidate

These are not properties of the question. They are properties of you under time pressure, and they are the ones your error log in F11.3 §4.2 will actually convict you of.

T-24 Anchoring on the first plausible option ★★★★★

Shape. Option (a) is plausible, you mark it, and (c) and (d) are never genuinely evaluated.

Remedy. Mechanical, no exceptions: **read all four options before marking anything**, even when (a) feels certain. Three seconds, and the highest-return three seconds in the paper.

T-25 The familiarity illusion ★★★★★

Shape. A question closely resembling one you have solved, with **one word altered**. You recall the **answer** instead of solving the **question**.

Remedy. Treat familiarity as a **warning**, not a gift, and re-read the stem word by word hunting the alteration. This is the explicit form of F11.1 §1.2's instruction to leave a question when you feel actively pulled towards a familiar-looking option: **in a UPSC paper, familiarity is very often engineered**.

T-26 Over-elimination on partial knowledge ★★★★★

Shape. You eliminate the **correct** option because one component is unfamiliar, reading unfamiliarity as falsity. It feels like rigour.

Why it matters. This is the exact mechanism by which F11.1 §1.2's arithmetic inverts: a false elimination turns a zero-expectation guess **negative**. It is also the mirror of T-13, which is why the two must be learned together.

Remedy. The **hard / soft** distinction from §1.2, applied consciously. Only hard eliminations move your probability. Soft-eliminated options **stay in the pool**.

T-27 The sunk-cost question ★★★★★★

Shape. Four minutes spent, and leaving now feels like wasting them.

Remedy. A hard **ninety-second ceiling** in the second pass, enforced by the clock at fixed question counts rather than by feel. The four minutes are already spent; the only live question is whether to spend more. Mark and move.

T-28 Bilingual ambiguity ★★★★★★

Shape. Specific to this paper. The Hindi and English texts occasionally diverge in precision, particularly for legal and accounting terms of art.

Remedy. Pick **one** primary language and read the other **only when the primary is ambiguous** — cross-reading everything burns time you do not have. For statutory questions prefer the **English** reading, the English text of Indian statutes generally being operative. Note the question number if a genuine discrepancy exists.

T-29 Panic-driven pattern hunting ★★★★★

Shape. You notice you have marked (c) six times running and change one.

Remedy. A **hard prohibition**: never let the distribution of your own previous answers influence a current answer. In the moment it will feel like insight. Note that F11.2's key is deliberately balanced at exactly 30/30/30/30 precisely so that there is no letter to fall back on.

T-30 The OMR drift ★★★★★

Shape. Not a knowledge trap, and the most expensive one in the paper. A skipped question is bubbled in the skipped row, and **every subsequent answer shifts by one**.

Remedy. Bubble in **blocks of ten** — never question-by-question, never all at the end. At each block boundary verify that the booklet question number and the OMR row number agree. In the final five minutes check **only the first bubble of each block of ten**: twelve checks, not a hundred and twenty, and a drift shows up immediately.

IMPORTANT · T-30 OUTRANKS EVERY CONTENT CHAPTER IN THIS MANUAL

A single undetected row shift can cost **forty marks or more**. That exceeds the entire planning weight of several modules. It is also the only trap in this catalogue with a **complete** remedy — the procedure above eliminates it, not merely reduces it.

Rehearse the block-of-ten audit in **every** mock from F11.2 onward, under F11.3 §1.1 conditions, until it costs you no conscious attention.

4. Where the Traps Were Learned — The Source-Paper Map ★★★★★

The APFC paper has a **thin question history**. The Commission that writes it has an enormous one. Question-setting conventions at UPSC are **institutional rather than paper-specific**: the same drafting habits, the same distractor techniques and often the same recycled content zones recur across the family.

So the traps in §3 are not derived from APFC papers alone, and should not be. This is the map.

Source paper	What it contributes	Priority
CSE Prelims GS Paper I	The definitive school of statement-based and pair-matching traps. The count format (T-03), used aggressively from 2023, is the hardest single trap family you will meet	Highest
Past APFC Recruitment Tests	The exact template — subject weighting, phrasing, numerical granularity. See F11.1 for the 2023 paper, item by item	Highest
EPFO EO/AO past papers	Direct ancestor: labour law, social security, accounting, EPFO administration. Doubly relevant now that EO/AO is not separately notified — see §1.1	Highest
CAPF (AC) Paper I	The closest cousin in breadth and difficulty. Polity, economy, history and general science at almost exactly APFC depth. Under-used by aspirants, therefore high-yield	Highest
CDS General Knowledge	Fast factual recall at APFC depth — freedom struggle, general science, static facts. Trains speed	High
NDA General Ability Test	General science and English usage slightly below APFC level but with the same trap grammar. Good for error-spotting and physics and chemistry basics	Medium-High
IES / ISS	The best available source for statistics and economics precision — index numbers, sampling, dispersion, national income accounting. Feeds F6.8 directly	Medium-High
ESE General Studies Paper I	Current events, environment, standards. Occasional overlap in developmental issues	Medium
CSE Mains GS-II and GS-III themes	Not for questions, but for framing labour codes, social security architecture and informal-sector debates. Interview value	Medium — interview

ACTION · SOLVE THEM AS SPECIMENS, NOT AS TESTS

The mistake is to sit these papers for a score. Sit them for a **diagnosis**.

For every question you get wrong in **any** of the papers above, record two things in the F11.3 §4.2 error log: the **trap code** from §3, and the **§6 confusion pair** that would have saved you.

After roughly four hundred questions across the family, count the codes. Candidates typically find that **five or six codes account for most of their losses**. That is your error signature.

Fixing six trap codes is a tractable project; "revising General Studies" is not.

HIGH YIELD · THE IMPORT DRILL, FOR LABOUR LAW AND SOCIAL SECURITY

Labour law and social security barely appear in CSE Prelims or CAPF. So their trap patterns cannot be observed — they must be **imported**.

Take the distractor architecture CSE Prelims applies to polity and **apply it yourself** to the bare Act: swap a section number, shift a threshold by one band, change *may* to *shall*, turn *or* into *and*, substitute the superseded figure for the current one.

Manufacturing traps against your own labour-law notes is the single most effective drill in this chapter, because it forces you to notice which numbers you hold without their slot — which is exactly what T-09 punishes.

5. The Numbers Ledger, and the Superseded-Value Trap ★★★★★

T-09 is the most dangerous trap in **this** paper specifically, because labour and social-security law is dense with numbers and **almost every number has a superseded predecessor and a near neighbour in another instrument**. The setter's easiest job in the whole paper is to lift the older figure, or the ESI figure, and place it beside the current one.

And in this cycle the field is wider than it has ever been, because **the entire instrument layer was replaced inside the last nine months**.

IMPORTANT · THE LEGAL POSITION, AND WHY IT MAKES T-09 THE TRAP OF THIS CYCLE

[AS AT 1 AUG 2026] — the record and the sources are in **F10.3 §1**.

Date	What changed
21 November 2025	All four labour codes brought into force, replacing 29 central labour Acts
29 June 2026	Three schemes notified under the Code on Social Security, 2020: the Employees' Provident Funds Scheme, 2026 , the Employees' Pension Scheme, 2026 and the Employees' Deposit-Linked Insurance Scheme, 2026 — replacing the 1952, 1995 and 1976 schemes respectively. EPS 2026 also replaced the Family Pension Scheme, 1971

What this does to the trap landscape is the single most important thing in this chapter.

Every Act and every scheme year that a candidate has spent months memorising is now a **superseded instrument** — which is to say, every one of them is now a **ready-made distractor**. The Industrial Disputes Act, 1947, the Trade Unions Act, 1926, the EPF & MP Act, 1952 as a free-standing source of powers, EPS-95: these are no longer the law, and an option naming them as current law is **false**.

But — and this is what makes it examinable rather than merely disruptive — most of the numbers did not move. F10.3 §1.3 records it precisely: EPS 2026 keeps the **formula and the contribution rates**, the **minimum pension remains ₹1,000**, and the **wage ceiling is still ₹15,000**.

So the paper can ask you two entirely different questions, and you must not confuse them:

1. **What is the figure?** — mostly unchanged, and the ledger below still holds
2. **Which instrument is it in, and from what date?** — almost entirely changed

A candidate who prepared the numbers but not the instruments will answer type 1 and fail type 2. That is T-23 and T-11 operating together at a scale this paper has never previously offered, and it is the highest-probability trap zone in the 2026 cycle.

Note also, per F10.3 §1.3, what it means for the post itself: **APFCs are notified under Chapter III of the Code on Social Security and appointed Recovery Officers**. The powers of inquiry and recovery now flow from **the Code**, not from the 1952 Act directly. An option grounding an APFC's powers in the 1952 Act is attractive, familiar, and wrong.

MUST MASTER · THE LEDGER'S THIRD COLUMN IS WHERE THE MARKS ARE

Build this on **one sheet** and revise it as a **single unit**. The third column is not decoration — it names the number the setter will actually put in front of you.

Then note the pattern down that column: almost every distractor is **either the superseded value or the correct value from a neighbouring statute**. Nothing is invented. That is why *recognising* a number is worthless and **slotting** it is everything.

5.1 The instrument layer — what is live, and what is now a distractor

Learn this **before** the numbers, because it decides whether a numerically correct option is still a legally correct one.

Subject	Live instrument	Now superseded — and therefore a distractor
Provident fund, pension, insurance, ESI, gratuity, maternity, employees' compensation	Code on Social Security, 2020 , in force 21 Nov 2025	EPF & MP Act 1952 · ESI Act 1948 · Gratuity Act 1972 · Maternity Benefit Act 1961 · Employees' Compensation Act 1923
Provident fund scheme	EPF Scheme, 2026	EPF Scheme, 1952
Pension scheme	EPS, 2026	EPS-95 , and the Family Pension Scheme, 1971
Deposit-linked insurance	EDLI Scheme, 2026	EDLI Scheme, 1976
Wages, bonus, equal remuneration	Code on Wages, 2019 , in force 21 Nov 2025	Payment of Wages 1936 · Minimum Wages 1948 · Payment of Bonus 1965 · Equal Remuneration 1976
Unions, standing orders, disputes	Industrial Relations Code, 2020	Trade Unions 1926 · Standing Orders 1946 · Industrial Disputes Act 1947
Safety, contract labour, factories, migrants	OSH & WC Code, 2020	Factories 1948 · Contract Labour 1970 · Inter-State Migrant Workmen 1979, and ten others
APFC's powers of inquiry and recovery	Chapter III, Code on Social Security — APFCs notified as Recovery Officers	Section 7A of the 1952 Act as a free-standing source

5.2 The numbers ledger

Item	Current value	The confusable value
Provident fund wage ceiling	₹15,000 — see the notification caution below	₹6,500, the pre-September-2014 figure, and the commonest distractor of all
Provident fund coverage threshold	20 or more persons	10 — which is the ESI and gratuity threshold
Employer's 12% split	8.33% to pension, 3.67% to provident fund — unchanged by EPS 2026	8.67 and 3.33 — a pure digit swap
Pension contribution cap	₹1,250 a month, being 8.33% of ₹15,000	₹1,800, which is 12% of ₹15,000
Central Government share in the pension scheme	1.16% of wages	1.61% — digit reversal
Deposit-linked insurance contribution	0.50%, employer only	1.00%, or any figure implying an employee share
Maximum assurance under the insurance scheme	₹7 lakh , on a 35× multiplier plus a capped bonus	₹6 lakh — correct only before April 2021
Pension superannuation age	58	60, imported from general retirement intuition
Early pension	from 50 , reduced	55
Minimum service for pension	10 years eligible service	5 years — which is the gratuity rule
Minimum monthly pension	₹1,000 — expressly retained by EPS 2026	₹2,000, ₹3,000 (the last is PM-SYM)
Pension claim settlement standard	20 days , with 12% interest where EPFO delays — new under EPS 2026	Any pre-2026 service standard
ESI wage ceiling	₹21,000 (₹25,000 for a person with disability)	₹15,000 (provident fund) or ₹24,000 (the old Payment of Wages ceiling)
ESI contribution	employer 3.25% , employee 0.75%	4.75 and 1.75 — correct only before July 2019

Item	Current value	The confusable value
Gratuity ceiling	₹20 lakh	₹10 lakh — correct only before March 2018
Gratuity qualifying service	5 years , waived on death or disablement	10 years
Minimum and maximum bonus	8.33% and 20%	10%
Maternity benefit	26 weeks for the first two children	12 weeks — correct for the third child onward, and pre-2017
Standing orders threshold	300 workers, IR Code	100 — the repealed 1946 Act figure
Prior permission for retrenchment, layoff, closure	300 workers, IR Code	100 — the repealed ID Act Chapter VB figure
Contract labour threshold	50 , OSH Code	20 — the repealed 1970 Act figure
Factory threshold	20 with power, 40 without, OSH Code	10 and 20 — the repealed Factories Act figures
EPF interest rate, 2025-26	8.25% — third consecutive year	8.15%, 8.10%, 8.50%

TRAP · THE FOUR THRESHOLD PAIRS, WHICH ARE ONE QUESTION IN FOUR DISGUISES

Standing orders 100 » 300. Retrenchment permission 100 » 300. Contract labour 20 » 50. Factory 10 with power and 20 without » 20 with power and 40 without.

Memorise them **as pairs**, never as single numbers, and know **which side of the arrow is the law**. Since 21 November 2025 the right-hand figure is operative and the left-hand figure is **repealed** — so the left-hand figure is now purely a distractor.

The favourite construction is a correct-sounding provision carrying the **pre-Code** number. That is T-23 in its purest form: a true statement made false by one overqualifying figure. And note the second-order trap — because these thresholds were debated for years before commencement, a great deal of published material still states the old figure as current.

IMPORTANT · THE NOTIFICATION DISCIPLINE, AND WHY THIS LEDGER IS NOT AN AUTHORITY

F10.2 §2.2 fixes the rule this chapter must obey: reporting does not distinguish between **proposed, departmentally approved, Cabinet approved and notified** — and an examiner does. **Only the last is law.**

The EPF wage ceiling is the live instance. It remains **₹15,000**; the widely reported **₹25,000** has been approved but **not notified**, and is therefore **not** the answer. A candidate who "updated" from a news headline gets this wrong, which is T-09 running forwards in time instead of backwards.

Two consequences for how you use §5:

1. **This ledger illustrates traps. It is not the authority for any figure.** Verify each against the **bare Code and the 2026 schemes** — not the repealed Acts — and against the current **EPFO circular**. The minimum assurance under the insurance scheme is the clearest case: figures of ₹2 lakh and ₹2.5 lakh both circulate because they belong to different notifications and different periods. The **₹7 lakh maximum** and the **35× multiplier** are the stable, examinable parts
2. **Modules 2 and 3 are not in src/** — register §9. Their labour-law and social-security content is the coldest material you own, it was written against the **repealed Acts**, and it must be checked against the four Codes and the 2026 schemes before you rely on a single figure in it. **Nothing in this chapter substitutes for that check** — and note that this is not a housekeeping remark: material written against the 1952, 1995 and 1976 schemes now teaches superseded instruments throughout

Diarise this with the F10.1 §4 verification sweep. Any parameter that can move should be verified in the **same** fortnight, once, from primary sources — not re-learned repeatedly from compilations.

6. The Confusion-Pair Compendium ★★★★★

This is the last-mile asset. Every row is a pair the paper has confused before, reduced to a **single discriminating line**. Do not read the two definitions; read the **difference**, because the difference is what is tested.

Read this section end to end once a week from now on. It takes about twenty-five minutes.

6.1 Labour law and social security

Pair	The discriminating line
Layoff / retrenchment	Layoff is temporary inability to employ with the relationship intact; retrenchment is permanent termination for non-disciplinary reasons
Retrenchment / closure	Retrenchment ends the worker's employment; closure ends the place of employment
Registration / recognition of a union	Registration was voluntary under the repealed 1926 Act, which had no recognition machinery at all ; recognition of a negotiating union arrived only with the IR Code, 2020
Interest on delay / damages for default	Interest is compensatory and at a fixed rate; damages are penal and graded by the period of default. Both now sit in the Code on Social Security ; the old s.7Q and s.14B labels belong to the repealed 1952 Act
Employee's / employer's contribution	The employee's 12% goes wholly to provident fund; the pension diversion of 8.33% comes out of the employer's share
EDLI / EPS funding	EDLI is funded by the employer alone ; EPS additionally receives the Central Government's 1.16%
EPF / ESI applicability	EPF at 20 or more with a ₹15,000 ceiling; ESI at 10 or more with a ₹21,000 ceiling
Bonus eligibility / calculation ceiling	Two different ceilings: one decides who qualifies , the other the notional wage the bonus is computed on . Knowing only one answers neither version of the question. Now governed by the Code on Wages , with the figures notified — verify before quoting either
Gratuity / EPS qualifying service	Gratuity needs 5 years, waived on death; EPS pension needs 10 years of eligible service
ID Act Chapter VA / VB	VA covered 50–99 workmen; VB covered 100 or more and required prior permission. Historical only — the ID Act is repealed, and the IR Code sets the threshold at 300
The repealed figure / the live figure	100 under the old ID Act; 300 under the IR Code — for standing orders and for retrenchment permission. Since 21 Nov 2025 only 300 is law
Minimum wage / floor wage	The minimum wage is fixed by the appropriate government for employments; the floor wage is a national statutory baseline introduced by the Code on Wages, below which no State may go

Pair	The discriminating line
Organised / formal	Organised describes the enterprise ; formal describes the worker's contract and social security — so a formal firm can employ informal workers
Works Committee / Grievance Redressal	Works Committee at 100 or more workmen; Grievance Redressal Machinery at 20 or more
Central Board of Trustees / PFRDA	The Board is statutory and governs EPFO, now under the Code on Social Security ; PFRDA is a separate regulator and does not regulate EPFO's schemes

6.2 Polity

Pair	The discriminating line
Money Bill / Financial Bill	Every Money Bill is a Financial Bill; only a Money Bill is certified by the Speaker and denies the Rajya Sabha any power beyond recommendation. No joint sitting for a Money Bill
Article 358 / 359	358 suspends Article 19 automatically , and only in an external emergency; 359 suspends the enforcement of specified rights by presidential order
Articles 352 / 356 / 360	Special majority within one month; simple majority within two months; and never invoked
Article 32 / 226	32 is itself a Fundamental Right and confined to Fundamental Rights, so relief cannot be refused; 226 is wider but discretionary
Prohibition / certiorari	Prohibition is preventive and stops proceedings; certiorari is curative and quashes an order already made
Habeas corpus / the rest	Habeas corpus is the only writ available against a private person
Prorogation / dissolution	Prorogation ends a session , by the President; dissolution ends the life of the Lok Sabha . The Rajya Sabha is never dissolved
No-confidence / censure	No-confidence needs no grounds , lies only in the Lok Sabha, and targets the whole Council; censure states grounds , may target one minister, and compels nothing
Policy / economy / token cut	Reduce the demand to ₹1 ; by a specified amount ; by exactly ₹100
Articles 72 / 161	Only the President can pardon a court-martial sentence and a death sentence
52nd / 91st Amendment	The 52nd created the Tenth Schedule; the 91st deleted the one-third split exception , keeping the two-thirds merger exception
42nd / 44th Amendment	The 42nd added <i>socialist, secular, integrity</i> and inserted 43A ; the 44th removed the right to property and protected Articles 20 and 21 in emergencies
Eleventh / Twelfth Schedule	29 subjects for Panchayats; 18 for Municipalities

Pair	The discriminating line
CAG / CGA	The CAG audits and is constitutional; the Controller General of Accounts maintains the accounts, inside the Ministry of Finance
Consolidated Fund / Public Account	Withdrawals from the Consolidated Fund need parliamentary appropriation ; the Public Account holds moneys held in trust — including provident funds — and needs none

6.3 Economy, accounting, auditing and statistics

Cross-references are to the chapters that teach these: F4.2, F6.1–F6.8, F7.1.

Pair	The discriminating line
CRR / SLR	CRR is held with the RBI and earns nothing ; SLR is held by the bank itself in specified assets and does earn. The location of the reserve is the discriminator — F4.2
Repo / MSF / SDF	MSF is the ceiling of the corridor, repo the policy rate, SDF the floor — and the SDF is uncollateralised , which is its defining feature — F4.2
Fiscal / revenue deficit	Fiscal deficit is total expenditure less total receipts excluding borrowings . Omit those two words and the definition becomes trivially zero — F4.3
Fiscal / primary deficit	Primary deficit is fiscal deficit minus interest payments , and is therefore smaller . Store the ordering as its own fact — T-20 — F4.3
GDP / GVA	GVA = GDP minus product taxes plus product subsidies . Learn the sign convention , not the sentence — F4.1
WPI / CPI	WPI excludes services entirely ; CPI includes them, and CPI-Combined is the inflation-targeting index — F4.2
CPI-C / CPI-IW	CPI-Combined is the NSO's inflation-target index; CPI-IW is the Labour Bureau's, and is the basis of dearness allowance — directly relevant to this post
Devaluation / depreciation	Devaluation is a deliberate official act under a fixed regime; depreciation is market-driven under a float
Provision / reserve	A provision is a charge against profit and is mandatory even in a loss year ; a reserve is an appropriation and needs profit — F6.2
Depletion / amortisation	Depletion for wasting natural resources ; amortisation for intangibles . Obsolescence is a cause of depreciation, not a parallel concept — F6.4
SLM / WDV	SLM gives a constant charge and can reach zero; WDV gives a falling charge and never fully writes off — F6.4
Vouching / verification	Vouching examines evidence for a transaction ; verification confirms existence, ownership and value of an asset. Valuation sits inside verification, not vouching — F6.7
Internal check / internal audit	Internal check is built into the division of duties ; internal audit is a separate appraisal . Both sit inside internal control — F6.7
Qualified / adverse opinion	Qualified means true and fair except for stated matters; adverse means not true and fair. They are not synonyms — F6.7

Pair	The discriminating line
Cash flow / fund flow	Cash flow tracks cash and equivalents ; fund flow tracks changes in working capital — F6.5
Laspeyres / Paasche	Base-year weights and current-year weights. <i>L before P as base before current</i> — F6.8
SD / coefficient of variation	SD carries the data's units ; the CV is unit-free and is therefore the correct measure for comparing two series — F6.8
Type I / Type II error	Rejecting a true null; accepting a false null — F6.8
Stratified / cluster sampling	Stratified divides into homogeneous strata and samples within each; cluster selects whole natural groups — F6.8
Indemnity / assurance	Indemnity restores the actual loss and does not apply to life insurance ; life assurance pays the sum assured in full. Subrogation and contribution likewise do not apply — F7.1

6.4 History, general science and computers

Pair	The discriminating line
Annie Besant / Sarojini Naidu	First woman Congress president, 1917; first Indian woman, 1925. Different questions, eight years apart
Dyarchy 1919 / 1935	1919 introduced it in the provinces ; 1935 abolished it there and introduced it at the Centre . Learn the migration , not the association
Communal Award / Poona Pact	The Award gave the depressed classes separate electorates ; the Pact replaced them with reserved seats in the general electorate . It changed the form of reservation, it did not abolish it
Champaran / Ahmedabad / Kheda	First satyagraha in India; first hunger strike ; first non-cooperation — 1917, 1918, 1918. Three different "firsts" inside two years
Lokhande 1884 / Madras Labour Union 1918	The first labour association ; the first organised trade union . Note that AITUC (1920) predates the Trade Unions Act (1926)
Cripps / Cabinet Mission	1942 and 1946 — Stafford Cripps was in both , which is why they are confused
INA founding / Bose's leadership	Formed 1942 ; Bose took charge in 1943 . He reorganised and led it; he did not found it
Hygrometer / hydrometer	Humidity; relative density of liquids . A phonetic trap, not a conceptual one — rehearse the letter
Barometer / manometer	Atmospheric pressure; gas pressure
Brass / bronze	Copper with zinc ; copper with tin . German silver contains no silver
Rickets / osteomalacia	The same vitamin D deficiency — in children, and in adults
RAM / ROM	Volatile; non-volatile — F9.5
Register / cache	The register is the fastest memory, inside the CPU; cache is second — F9.5
Compiler / interpreter	Whole program at once; line by line — F9.6
Switch / router	Data link layer, MAC addresses; network layer, IP addresses — F9.7
SMTP / POP3	Sending; receiving — F9.7

Pair	The discriminating line
Virus / worm	A virus needs a host and user action ; a worm self-replicates across networks independently
Malaria's agent	Protozoan — <i>Plasmodium</i> . The most misclassified disease in Indian competitive exams — F9.4

7. The Elimination Ladder ★★★★★

Knowing the traps is necessary and not sufficient. Under time pressure, recognition fails unless it has become a **procedure**. This is deliberately mechanical, because mechanical is what survives adrenaline.

7.1 The ladder

Work down it. Stop as soon as one option remains.

Rung	Test
1	Hard contradiction — eliminate anything contradicting a fact you are certain of. The only rung that earns near-certainty
2	Internal incoherence — a misused term of art, or a legal impossibility, such as a Governor pardoning a death sentence, or an ordinance amending the Constitution
3	Absolutes — suspect <i>always, never, only, all, cannot</i> , and try to build one counter-example (T-07)
4	The superseded number — is this the previous value of this parameter, or the current value of a neighbouring one? (T-09, \$5)
5	Scope mismatch — broader or narrower than the stem. Resolves most best-answer questions (T-04, T-05)
6	The tail clause — re-read the final clause of every surviving long option (T-22)
7	Hedged over absolute — two left, one hedged and one absolute, nothing else to go on: take the hedged one (T-08)
8	The structural tell — if a surviving option is a near-paraphrase of one you already eliminated, prefer the option that stands alone . Distractors are usually built in pairs around a single misconception
9	Commit — per F11.1 §1.2, a guess after even one hard elimination is positive. Answer it, and do not revisit it

MUST MASTER · THE RULE THAT GOVERNS THE WHOLE LADDER

Rungs 3 to 8 produce **soft** eliminations. Rungs 1 and 2 produce **hard** ones.

Soft eliminations are for **ranking** the surviving options, **not** for removing them from the pool. The moment you treat a rung-3 hunch as a rung-1 fact, T-26 has you, and F11.1 §1.2's arithmetic quietly turns against you.

7.2 Never mark an option because it is true

Mark it because it answers the question that was asked. A large share of UPSC errors are perfectly true statements marked in response to a question that did not ask for them. This one sentence is the compressed form of T-01, T-04 and T-05 together.

7.3 Format-specific rules

Format	The rule
Count — <i>how many of the above</i>	T, F or ? beside each statement, in the booklet. Count arithmetically, never by feel. One ? makes it a probability question, not a knowledge question
Pair matching	Adjudicate in order of your confidence. Resolve the certain pairs first. If a famous pair looks right and an obscure one will not resolve, re-examine the famous pair — the question was built around it
Assertion-Reason	Establish both truths before testing the link. <i>Both true, R does not explain A</i> is the correct answer far more often than it is chosen
Ordering	Do not build the full sequence. Fix the earliest and latest , then discard every option inconsistent with both. Usually decides it without the middle terms
Computation	Estimate before calculating. If the estimate excludes three options, no calculation is needed. The highest-yield time saver in the quantitative section
Error spotting	Check subject-verb agreement first — the largest category by a wide margin — then prepositions, then tense. And take "no error" seriously: candidates under-select it because finding no error feels like failure

7.4 OMR discipline

The pass structure is F11.1 §1.3's and the day protocol is F11.3 §5's; this adds only the audit.

ACTION · THE BLOCK-OF-TEN AUDIT

1. **Bubble in blocks of ten** — never question-by-question, never all at the end
2. **At each block boundary**, verify booklet question number against OMR row number
3. **In the last five minutes**, check **only the first bubble of each block of ten** — twelve checks
4. **Never erase and change an answer in the last two minutes** unless you have identified a **specific factual error** in your reasoning. Late changes made on feeling are, on candidates' own post-mortems, more often wrong than right (T-29)

8. Question Bank — 30 Trap-Diagnostic Items

These are **not** content questions. Each is built to spring a specific trap, and the point is to discover **which traps catch you**. Take them untimed, but commit to each answer before moving on. **The trap code is given with each answer in §9, so record the codes you miss** — that list is the output of this chapter.

Written fresh. No verbatim question-paper text. Statutory figures are used to illustrate a trap and are subject to §5's verification caution.

8.1 Stem traps

Q1. All of the following are contributions made by the **employer** under the provident fund, pension and deposit-linked insurance schemes framed under the Code on Social Security, 2020 **except** (a) 3.67% to the provident fund (b) 8.33% to the pension scheme (c) 0.50% to deposit-linked insurance (d) 1.75% to the Employees' State Insurance Corporation

Q2. Consider the following statements about coverage for provident fund purposes under the law now in force. **I.** An establishment once covered continues to be governed by the Act even if its employee strength later falls below the threshold. **II.** Newly established establishments enjoy a three-year exemption from the Act. **III.** An establishment employing fewer than the threshold number of persons can never be covered, even with the consent of the employer and the employees. How many of the above are correct? (a) Only one (b) Only two (c) All three (d) None

Q3. The contribution of the Central Government to the Employees' Pension Scheme is (a) 1.16% of wages (b) 1.61% of wages (c) 8.33% of wages (d) nil

Q4. Which one of the following is **not** correct about the payment of bonus under the Code on Wages, 2019? (a) Minimum bonus is payable even in a year of loss (b) Eligibility is subject to a notified wage limit (c) Maximum bonus is 20% of salary (d) Bonus is calculated on the actual salary drawn

Q5. Consider the following pairs of contribution rates. **I.** ESI, employer — 3.25% **II.** ESI, employee — 1.75% **III.** EDLI, employer — 0.50% **IV.** EPF administrative charges — 0.50% How many pairs are correctly matched? (a) One (b) Two (c) Three (d) All four

Q6. Under the **Industrial Relations Code, 2020**, prior permission of the appropriate government for retrenchment is required in an industrial establishment employing not less than (a) 50 workers (b) 100 workers (c) 300 workers (d) 1,000 workers

Q7. Which of the following ILO Conventions has India **not** ratified? (a) No. 29, Forced Labour (b) No. 100, Equal Remuneration (c) No. 182, Worst Forms of Child Labour (d) No. 98, Right to Organise and Collective Bargaining

Q8. Article 43A of the Constitution, on the participation of workers in the management of undertakings, was inserted by the (a) 42nd Amendment (b) 44th Amendment (c) 73rd Amendment (d) 86th Amendment

Q9. Which one of the following bodies is a **statutory** body? (a) NITI Aayog (b) The Finance Commission (c) The Comptroller and Auditor General (d) EPFO's Central Board of Trustees

Q10. The wage ceiling for provident fund coverage is currently (a) ₹15,000 a month (b) ₹21,000 a month (c) ₹24,000 a month (d) ₹25,000 a month

8.2 Logic traps

Q11. Assertion (A): The five-year continuous service requirement for gratuity does not always apply.

Reason (R): The law excludes seasonal establishments from its scope. (a) Both A and R are true, and R explains A (b) Both true, but R does not explain A (c) A is true, R is false (d) A is false, R is true

Q12. Assertion (A): The Employees' Pension Scheme receives a contribution from the Central Government.

Reason (R): The Employees' Provident Fund is a statutory fund managed by a tripartite Central Board of Trustees. (a) Both true, and R explains A (b) Both true, but R does not explain A (c) A true, R false (d) A false, R true

Q13. Which one of the following statements is correct? (a) A layoff permanently terminates the employment relationship (b) Retrenchment includes termination as a punishment for misconduct (c) Layoff and retrenchment are alternative names for the same event (d) Closure refers to the permanent shutting down of a place of employment

Q14. An increase in the repo rate by the Reserve Bank of India will, other things being equal, (a) expand the money supply (b) contract the money supply (c) leave the money supply unchanged (d) reduce the statutory liquidity ratio

Q15. Which one of the following is **true** of the Cash Reserve Ratio and the Statutory Liquidity Ratio? (a) Both are held with the Reserve Bank of India (b) Both are held by the bank itself (c) CRR is held with the RBI and earns no interest, while SLR is held by the bank itself (d) SLR is held with the RBI and CRR by the bank itself

Q16. Consider the following statements about the Trade Unions Act, 1926, since subsumed into the Industrial Relations Code, 2020. **I.** Registration of a trade union is compulsory. **II.** The Act provides machinery for the recognition of a union as a bargaining agent. **III.** A registered trade union must maintain a minimum of seven members. How many of the above are correct? (a) Only one (b) Only two (c) All three (d) None

Q17. Fiscal deficit is best defined as (a) total expenditure minus total receipts (b) total expenditure minus total receipts excluding borrowings (c) revenue expenditure minus revenue receipts (d) fiscal deficit minus interest payments

Q18. Which of the following errors would **not** be disclosed by a trial balance? (a) A one-sided posting error (b) An error of complete omission (c) Posting a debit as a credit (d) An arithmetical error in balancing an account

Q19. Life insurance is **not** a contract of indemnity. It follows that (a) insurable interest is not required (b) utmost good faith does not apply (c) the policy is unenforceable at law (d) subrogation and contribution do not apply

Q20. Arrange in chronological order: **1.** Trade Unions Act **2.** All India Trade Union Congress founded **3.** Madras Labour Union founded **4.** Industrial Disputes Act (a) 3-2-1-4 (b) 2-3-1-4 (c) 3-1-2-4 (d) 1-3-2-4

8.3 Mixed, with the traps unlabelled

Q21. Which one of the following is **not** a fundamental accounting assumption? (a) Going concern (b) Consistency (c) Accrual (d) Conservatism

Q22. Provident fund moneys received by the Government are credited to the (a) Consolidated Fund of India (b) Contingency Fund of India (c) Public Account of India (d) Not applicable — they are not received by the

Government at all

- Q23.** In the Laspeyres price index, the weights used are the quantities of the (a) base year (b) current year (c) geometric mean of both years (d) year of maximum output
- Q24.** A sum increases by 20% and then decreases by 20%. The net change is (a) no change (b) a 4% increase (c) a 4% decrease (d) a 2% decrease
- Q25.** A vehicle covers half a given distance at 40 km/h and the other half at 60 km/h. Its average speed is (a) 50 km/h (b) 48 km/h (c) 52 km/h (d) 45 km/h
- Q26.** Which one of the following sentences is grammatically correct? (a) One of my friends are a doctor (b) One of my friends is a doctor (c) One of my friend is a doctor (d) One of my friends were a doctor
- Q27.** Consider the following statements about the deposit-linked insurance scheme administered by EPFO. **I.** The employer alone contributes to the scheme. **II.** The maximum assurance benefit is ₹6 lakh. **III.** The benefit includes a bonus component subject to a ceiling. How many of the above are correct? (a) Only one (b) Only two (c) All three (d) None
- Q28.** Which one of the following pairs is correctly matched? (a) Hygrometer — relative density of liquids (b) Manometer — atmospheric pressure (c) Hydrometer — humidity (d) Anemometer — wind speed
- Q29.** Labour is a subject in which List of the Seventh Schedule? (a) Union List (b) State List (c) Concurrent List (d) It is not enumerated in any List
- Q30.** The requirement of five years' continuous service for gratuity is **not** applicable where the termination is due to (a) resignation (b) superannuation (c) death or disablement (d) closure of the establishment

9. Answers, Explanations and Trap Codes

Read every explanation, including for the items you answered correctly — the **code** matters more than the mark here. Then complete §9.4.

9.1 Stem traps

Q	Ans	Trap	Explanation
1	d	T-01, T-09	ESI sits in a different Chapter of the Code and arises under none of the three provident-fund schemes, so it does not belong in this list. The figure is doubly wrong: employer ESI is 3.25% , and 1.75% is the superseded employee rate . Note the construction — (a), (b) and (c) are all true , which is what makes them feel like answers under a <i>NOT</i> stem
2	a	T-03, T-07	Only I. II describes the infancy protection deleted in 1988 — a provision that was true in a previous decade. III ignores voluntary coverage by agreement, so <i>can never</i> is a false absolute
3	a	T-09	1.16% . (b) is a digit reversal; (c) is the employer's pension diversion , offered as the Government's share — the slot-confusion form of T-09
4	d	T-01	Bonus is calculated on ₹7,000 or the minimum wage, whichever is higher , not on actual salary. The Act has two ceilings and this question turns on knowing which is which
5	c	T-06, T-09	Three. Pair II is the pre-July-2019 employee rate; it is now 0.75% . A single superseded value inside a pair-count item
6	c	T-09, T-23	300 under the Code. (b) 100 is the repealed Industrial Disputes Act figure — a number that was correct until 21 November 2025 and is now purely a distractor. See §5.2's four threshold pairs
7	d	T-01	Convention 98 , and also 87 — freedom of association and collective bargaining. The negative fact is asked far more often than any positive one here, because it sits at the centre of every debate on the IR Code
8	a	T-10	42nd Amendment , 1976. The 44th is the standard distractor, because it is the other famous emergency-era amendment
9	d	T-12	EPFO's Central Board of Trustees , constituted under the EPF & MP Act. The Finance Commission and the CAG are constitutional ; NITI Aayog is neither — it is an executive body
10	a	T-09	₹15,000 . ₹25,000 has been approved but not notified , and therefore is not the answer. This is T-09 running forwards in time, and it is exactly F10.2 §2.2's <i>proposed / approved / notified</i> discipline

9.2 Logic traps

Q	Ans	Trap	Explanation
11	c	T-14, T-16	A is true, R is false. The requirement is waived on death or disablement — not because seasonal establishments are excluded. They are covered , at seven days per year. A true assertion with a fabricated reason
12	b	T-14	Both true, R does not explain A. The Government's 1.16% flows from the pension scheme's funding design , not from the tripartite governance of the provident fund. A true, adjacent, irrelevant reason — the commonest correct answer in this format and the least often chosen
13	d	T-21	Closure is the permanent shutting down of a place of employment. (a) inverts layoff, which is temporary with the relationship intact. (b) is false — retrenchment excludes punitive termination. (c) is the near-synonym error itself
14	b	T-15	Contract. A higher repo rate makes central-bank funds dearer. (a) is straightforward reversed causation. (d) is unrelated — the SLR is not set by the repo rate
15	c	T-21	The location of the reserve is the whole distinction. CRR sits with the RBI and earns nothing; SLR sits with the bank in specified liquid assets and does earn a return
16	a	T-03, T-21	Only III. Registration was voluntary , not compulsory. And the 1926 Act had no recognition machinery at all — recognition of a negotiating union arrived only with the IR Code, 2020 . Registration and recognition are the classic near-synonym failure in this subject
17	b	T-21, T-22	Excluding borrowings is the operative phrase; omit it, as (a) does, and the quantity is trivially zero. (c) defines the revenue deficit and (d) the primary deficit — three definitions in one option set
18	b	T-01	An error of complete omission. The unifying logic is that a trial balance detects only errors that break the equality of debits and credits, so any error preserving that equality passes. (a), (c) and (d) all create an imbalance. Learn the logic and you can derive the list under pressure
19	d	T-16, T-21	Subrogation and contribution do not apply. They are corollaries of indemnity. Insurable interest and utmost good faith apply to all insurance contracts , so (a) and (b) are false, and (c) is a non-sequitur

Q	Ans	Trap	Explanation
20	a	T-19	3-2-1-4: Madras Labour Union 1918 , AITUC 1920 , Trade Unions Act 1926 , Industrial Disputes Act 1947 . Note the relationship worth holding explicitly: the first central trade union organisation existed before there was any law to register it

9.3 Mixed

Q	Ans	Trap	Explanation
21	d	T-12	Conservatism is a convention, not a fundamental assumption. The three assumptions are going concern, consistency and accrual . Consistency appears in both lists, which is what makes this item work — a category swap rather than a factual error
22	c	—	The Public Account of India. The Government holds provident fund moneys as a banker or trustee , so withdrawals need no parliamentary appropriation — unlike the Consolidated Fund. A cross-domain item joining polity, accounting and social security, and exactly the kind this paper favours
23	a	T-21	Base-year quantities. Paasche uses current-year quantities and Fisher's ideal is the geometric mean of the two. <i>L before P as base before current</i>
24	c	—	A 4% decrease. Successive changes are not additive : the net is $a + b + ab/100 = 20 - 20 - 4$. Any increase followed by an equal percentage decrease always yields a net loss , of exactly the percentage squared over one hundred
25	b	—	48 km/h. Equal distances require the harmonic mean, $2xy/(x+y)$. (a) 50 is the arithmetic mean, which would be correct only for equal times — and it is the option most candidates take
26	b	—	One of my friends is a doctor. <i>One of the</i> + plural noun + singular verb: the subject is <i>one</i> . (c) wrongly singularises the noun
27	b	T-09	Two — I and III. The maximum is ₹7 lakh ; ₹6 lakh was correct before April 2021 . A superseded value sitting inside a count item — T-09 and T-03 compounded
28	d	T-21	Anemometer — wind speed. (a) and (c) are the hygrometer / hydrometer swap, and (b) attributes atmospheric pressure to the manometer, which measures gas pressure. Three distractors, two phonetic traps
29	c	T-12	Concurrent List — entries 22, 23 and 24 . Candidates place labour in the State List because labour administration is largely state-run. That is administration, not legislative competence
30	c	T-16	Death or disablement. Five years is necessary in the ordinary case, not in every case — the cleanest illustration of necessary-versus-sufficient in the whole syllabus

9.4 Now score the diagnosis, not the marks

CHECK YOURSELF · CONVERT THIS INTO YOUR ERROR SIGNATURE

1. **List the trap codes you missed.** Not the subjects — the **codes**
2. **Count them.** A code appearing twice or more is a **pattern**, not bad luck
3. **Write the top three on the F11.3 §4.2 error-log sheet** as standing watch items
4. **Re-read only those three entries in §3**, and the §7 rung that answers each

Then read the interpretation below, because *which* code dominates dictates an entirely different remedy.

If your dominant code is	The remedy is	And it is not
T-01 / T-03 / T-06	The §2 stem protocol, drilled until automatic	More content revision — this is a reading failure
T-09	§5's numbers ledger, revised as a single unit with the third column	Reading the Acts again
T-10 / T-11 / T-12	Cluster-and-narrative rehearsal, and the three pedigree lists	Rote pairs
T-14 / T-16	The fixed three-step order, and <i>required versus enough</i>	Knowing more law
T-21	§6, weekly, end to end	Re-reading two separate definitions
T-24 / T-25 / T-26	The hard / soft discipline in §1.2 and §7.1	Anything content-related at all
T-30	The block-of-ten audit, rehearsed in every mock	Ever forgivable

IMPORTANT · THE FINDING THAT SURPRISES ALMOST EVERYONE

Candidates arrive expecting the log to convict them of **knowledge gaps**. It usually convicts them of **stem-reading and over-elimination** — T-01, T-24 and T-26.

That is good news, and it is the reason this chapter sits in Module 11. Those three cost **nothing** to fix relative to a syllabus gap. But they will not fix themselves, and they are invisible unless you record the **cause** honestly rather than logging every error as *did not know*.

10. Wall Sheet — F11.4

MEMORY · CUT THIS OUT

NEVER MARK AN OPTION BECAUSE IT IS TRUE. MARK IT BECAUSE IT ANSWERS THE QUESTION ASKED

CIRCLE THE NEGATION BEFORE YOU LOOK AT ANY OPTION

READ ALL FOUR OPTIONS. EVERY TIME. EVEN WHEN (a) IS OBVIOUS

MARK EVERY *AND*, *OR*, *NOT* IN A STATUTORY OPTION

A NUMBER YOU RECOGNISE BUT CANNOT SLOT IS A TRAP. WHICH ACT? WHICH YEAR?

THE DISTRACTOR IS THE SUPERSEDED VALUE, OR THE NEIGHBOURING ACT'S VALUE. NOTHING IS INVENTED

APPROVED IS NOT NOTIFIED. ONLY NOTIFIED IS LAW

CODES IN FORCE 21 NOV 2025 · PF, PENSION AND INSURANCE SCHEMES REPLACED 29 JUNE 2026

THE NUMBERS MOSTLY DID NOT MOVE. THE INSTRUMENTS ALL DID. THE PAPER CAN ASK EITHER

HARD ELIMINATION = A FACT CONTRADICTS IT. SOFT = I DON'T RECOGNISE IT. ONLY HARD COUNTS

ONE ? IN A COUNT QUESTION MAKES IT A PROBABILITY QUESTION. STILL ATTEMPT IT

BOTH TRUE, R DOES NOT EXPLAIN A — THE ANSWER YOU CHOOSE LEAST AND SHOULD CHOOSE MORE

ABSOLUTES USUALLY FALSE. HEDGES USUALLY TRUE. NEVER DECIDE ON THAT ALONE

ORDERING: FIX EARLIEST AND LATEST. IGNORE THE MIDDLE

ESTIMATE BEFORE YOU CALCULATE

FAMILIAR MEANS ENGINEERED. SLOW DOWN AND FIND THE ALTERED WORD

NINETY SECONDS, THEN MARK AND MOVE. THE FOUR MINUTES ARE ALREADY SPENT

BUBBLE IN BLOCKS OF TEN. CHECK THE FIRST BUBBLE OF EACH BLOCK AT THE END

NEVER CHANGE AN ANSWER IN THE LAST TWO MINUTES ON A FEELING

YOUR PREVIOUS ANSWERS CARRY NO INFORMATION. THERE IS NO LETTER TO FALL BACK ON

ONE LINE FOR THE INTERVIEW A wrong answer in this paper is rarely a gap in knowledge; far more often it is a correct fact applied to a question that asked something slightly different, which is why the remedy is a reading procedure rather than more reading.

ACTION · WHAT THIS CHAPTER ASKS OF YOU

1. **Install the §2 protocol this week** — in every practice set, not only in mocks
2. **Build the §5 ledger on one sheet**, third column included, and verify it against the bare Acts and current EPFO circulars in the **same** sweep as F10.1 §4
3. **Read §6 end to end once a week** from now until the paper. Twenty-five minutes
4. **Log the trap code and the §6 pair for every error**, in every paper from every source in §4, on the F11.3 §4.2 sheet
5. **Rehearse the block-of-ten OMR audit** in every mock from F11.2 onward until it is invisible

And the standing caveat, because this chapter names a great many numbers: **verify every statutory figure against the bare Act and the current circular before you rely on it.** §5 illustrates traps. It is not the authority.